THE CASE AGAINST COERCION

How families, kinship networks and households become spaces where women's desires, refusals and freedoms are monitored, negotiated or suppressed



The family is where every Indian woman first learns whether her 'no' counts. This section examines how households, kinship networks and marriages—the spaces meant to protect women—become the spaces where their refusals are most closely monitored, negotiated or overruled. The questions move from everyday family interactions to the most contested territory in Indian law: consent within marriage.

Only 38 per cent say their refusal to an elder or family member is respected. For the rest, a 'no' triggers moves to persuade, or is read as defiance. At weddings, parties and family gatherings, just 29 per cent say a woman's refusal to participate is respected. More than a quarter report being pressured into physical contact such as hugs or sitting close under the label of "culture" or "tradition". When refusal is framed as disrespect to family honour, women are not just refusing a person; they are refusing an institution.

Marriage sharpens the question. About half of the respondents say they can refuse sex in a marriage or long-term relationship and expect it to be respected. The rest report being questioned, challenged or worn down by pressure and emotional guilt. The survey's most serious numbers sit here: 17 per cent report being physically forced into intercourse by a husband or partner. Coercion inside relationships, the data shows, cuts across class, education and geography.

Yet the same section carries evidence of a shift in conviction. A clear majority, 66 per cent, believe rape can take place within marriage, a direct rejection of the idea that a wedding means permanent sanction. A clear three-fourth support legal recognition of marital rape, though the largest group, 43 per cent, wants safeguards against misuse rather than unconditional criminalisation. On the judiciary's persistent refusal to recognise marital rape, 44 per cent call it patently unfair

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